partnership with the United States.[2] The growth in the India–US relationship in the last quarter of a century is therefore a pan-partisan trend. Yet, in his first two years at the helm since May 2014, Modi brought a qualitative change in the Indo–US relationship.[3] From resolving the prickly issue of civil nuclear energy cooperation to a significant upgrade in defence cooperation, as well as arriving at a common understanding on various international issues, Indo–US relations by 2016 seemed to have reached an "extraordinarily good place."[4]

This is a remarkable development for two reasons. First, in the last few years of Modi's predecessor, Manmohan Singh, Indo–US relations had seemed adrift. Second, since 2005, Narendra Modi had been denied a visa by the US government due to his alleged involvement in the 2002 Gujarat riots, and an impression lingered in India that the visa issue may cast a shadow on Indo–US ties in the event of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) achieving power.

This chapter examines the evolution in Indo–US relations and argues that the Modi government, by redefining the parameters of this bilateral relationship, has delinked India's strategic autonomy from the policy of non-alignment. It first discusses the origins and evolution in the practice of non-alignment by explicating changes in Cold War and post–Cold War Indian foreign policy behaviour. Subsequently, the chapter elaborates on the significant progress made in the bilateral relationship under the Modi government by underlining the rationale behind Modi's outreach to the United States. Based on the framework outlined by the editors in the introduction of this volume, the chapter furthermore discusses where on the spectrum of alignment – weak, moderate, or strong – India's relationship with the United States now is best characterised.

Three factors appear to have had a significant influence on India altering its policy towards the United States: at the